

THREAT ADVISORY



ACTOR REPORT

BackdoorDiplomacy targets the telecom industry in the Middle East

Date of Publication

December 7, 2022

Admiralty code

A1

TA Number

TA2022285

Summary

First Appearance: 2017

Actor Name: BackdoorDiplomacy

Target Region: Albania, Bhutan, Croatia, Georgia, Germany, Ghana, India, Libya, Namibia, Nigeria, Poland, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Sri Lanka, UAE, Uzbekistan.

Target Sectors: Government, Telecommunications.

Actor Map



CVE

CVE	NAME	PATCH
CVE-2021-26855	Microsoft Exchange Server Remote Code Execution Vulnerability	

Actor Details

#1

BackdoorDiplomacy, an advanced persistent threat (APT) gang with roots in China, is most likely behind a hostile campaign targeting the Middle East. The espionage action, aimed at a Middle Eastern telecom operator, is reported to have begun on August 19, 2021, with the successful exploitation of ProxyShell weaknesses (CVE-2021-26855) in the Microsoft Exchange Server.

#2

Binaries vulnerable to side-loading techniques were used in the initial compromise, along with a combination of open-source and custom tools like Irafau and Quarian backdoors and open-source tools like ToRat, Asyncrat, and Merlin to conduct reconnaissance, move laterally around the victim's environment, and elude detection.

Actor Group

NAME	ORIGIN	TARGET REGIONS	TARGET INDUSTRIES
BackdoorDiplomacy	China	Albania, Bhutan, Croatia, Georgia, Germany, Ghana, India, Libya, Namibia, Nigeria, Poland, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, Sri Lanka, UAE, Uzbekistan.	Government, Telecommunications.
	MOTIVE		
	Information theft and Espionage		

Recommendations



Security Leaders

Phishing simulations and routine education and awareness training and communications rarely account for MFA fatigue and web browser hygiene. Integrate and communicate all lessons learned.



Security Engineers

- **Uni5 Users:** This is an actionable threat advisory in HivePro Uni5. Prioritize and block all indicators attributed to the threat actor through your Command Center. Test your controls with Uni5’s Breach & Attack Simulation.
- **All Engineers:** Refer to and action upon the ‘Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs’ & ‘Indicators of Compromise (IoC)’ on the following pages.



 Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

<u>TA0042</u> Resource Development	<u>TA0001</u> Initial Access	<u>TA0005</u> Defense Evasion	<u>TA0007</u> Discovery
<u>TA0009</u> Collection	<u>TA0010</u> Exfiltration	<u>TA0011</u> Command and Control	<u>TA0040</u> Impact
<u>T1190</u> Exploit Public-Facing Application	<u>T1574</u> Hijack Execution Flow	<u>T1574.001</u> DLL Search Order Hijacking	<u>T1105</u> Ingress Tool Transfer
<u>T1074</u> Data Staged	<u>T1074.001</u> Local Data Staging	<u>T1036</u> Masquerading	<u>T1036.004</u> Masquerade Task or Service
<u>T1588</u> Obtain Capabilities	<u>T1588.001</u> Malware	<u>T1082</u> System Information Discovery	<u>T1560</u> Archive Collected Data

 Indicator of Compromise (IOC)

TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	06faa40b967de7168d16fec0519b77c5e319c6dc021578ed1eb8b337879018fe,eff22d43a0e66e4df60ab9355fa41b73481faea4b3aa6905eac3888bc1a62ffa,bbcd7dc60406a9fa439d183a10ad253426bae59424a0a1b91051d83d26bb0964,9d167adc290de378071c31cfd8f2059523e978c6f14a7079157d564f976c544b,e2589f9942e9ec6b9c385fec897ffc3a71fcd8d7e440e3302efc78760c40f926,c9d5dc956841e000bfd8762e2f0b48b66c79b79500e894b4efa7fb9ba17e4e9e,ec6fcff9ff738b6336b37aaa22e8afa7d66d9f71411430942aed05e98b3f4cd5,a43a4cd9c2561a4213011de36ac24ee1bf587663ed2f2ae1b1eac94aa2d48824,7ed44a0e548ba9a3adc1eb4fbf49e773bd9c932f95efc13a092af5bed30d3595,f293ab13a04ff32ebf9e925b42eca80a57604d231ae36e22834bea0dbdcf26e2,d1948085fc662f7aed592af2eab9f367b3040bba873fec24b939395515f54a83,99f31526fa18dc8c5f09b212909a9df889ea0bc3da979e4892666d626cc4aaf0,07e8b2c8cf5fcd9d29cf864cda3c5c2df3999c35a5da28a18af5dedd5f1db60a,6373ee72c811cf77a46e0cffd3c8f83d02173946b714d946e4c4c91cef41685f,d583189d66b0aa09405a0ed2440c72f741caedb250525be2b17a1f9616fab9e6,99e62952f66b487349493657d6aec8456afef0fb72aad084c388677912210bf9,b87580211c1748c7f223d6bfc96cd8eca5a19022758d964b40612639dfbe147d,363a2006c8faff9e533093d1562028c4b53d5be52028bb91259debc472399c9b,7c92d3754c6278636ff980a3b3ef6bd9b817eeeb7fc8524034858e1148acf116,132d9ce88304ec29c10c7744c81746de8be7a205b9c8dbdfb42b058bcc34ccd1

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IP Adresses	185.80.201[.]87 140.82.38[.]177 199.247.19[.]24 208.85.23[.]64 70.34.248[.]149 136.244.112[.]39 43.251.105[.]139 103.152.14[.]162 152.32.181[.]55 192.155.86[.]128

Patch Link

<https://msrc.microsoft.com/update-guide/vulnerability/CVE-2021-26855>

References

<https://www.bitdefender.com/blog/labs/backdoor-diplomacy-wields-new-tools-in-fresh-middle-east-campaign>

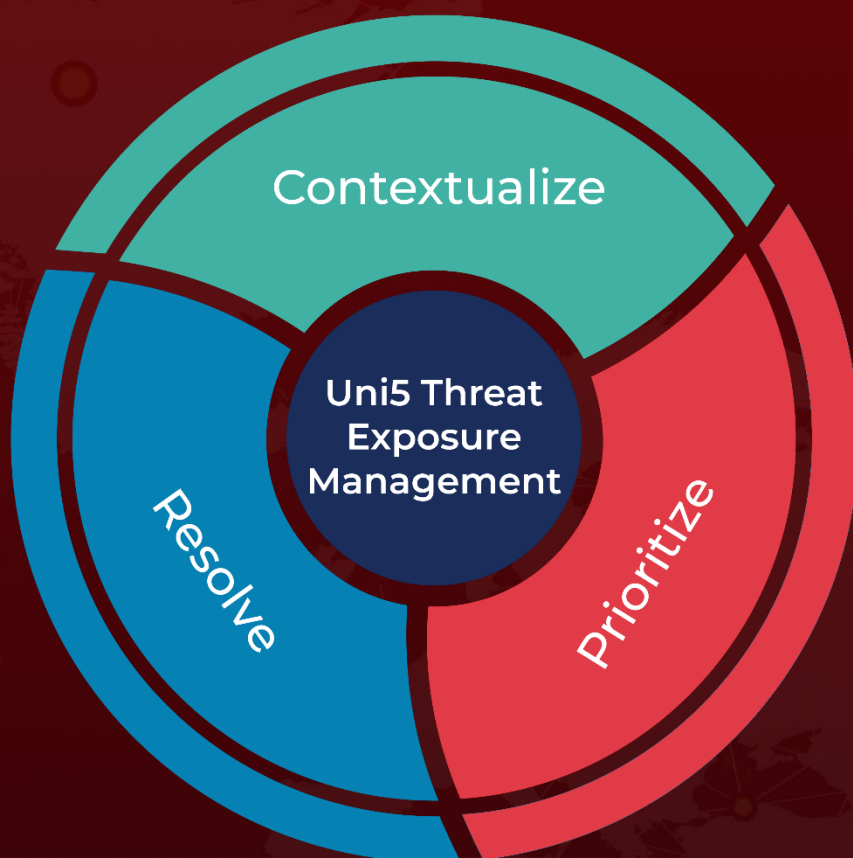
<https://www.eset.com/us/about/newsroom/press-releases/new-apt-group-backdoordiplomacy-attacks-diplomats-in-africa-and-the-middle-east-eset-research-disco-1/>

<https://attack.mitre.org/groups/G0135/>

What Next?

At **HivePro**, it is our mission to detect the most likely threats to your organization and to help you prevent them from happening.

Book a free demo with **Hive Pro Uni5**: Threat Exposure Management Platform.



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December 7, 2022 • 3:00 AM

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